

It also concerns the whole notion of male control. At one point, Gittes asks Cross why he feels the need to be richer: "How much better can you eat? What can you buy that you can't already afford?" "The future, Mr. Gittes," Cross replies, "The future." Women and water are the source of the future that Cross wants to control. And in his own way, Gittes, too, is pursuing control, probing and sticking his nose in where it is unwelcome.

His investigations lead to one of *Chinatown*'s nastiest and most memorable scenes. Gittes has his nose slit by a thug, played by Polanski himself: "You know what happens to nosy fellows? Huh? No? Wanna guess? Huh? No? Okay. They lose their noses." It is a kind of emasculation, and Gittes's dogged determination to solve the mystery reflects his need to regain control.



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You have to show violence the way it is. If you don't show it realistically, then that's immoral and harmful.

Roman Polanski

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The problem for Gittes is that he is living, metaphorically, in Chinatown, a place that holds bad memories for him, which date back to his time spent in the police force. Yet it is Gittes himself who in the end chooses Chinatown, a world where anything goes, for the movie's tragic denouement. There is no point in trying to do the right thing, his former police colleague tells him in the movie's final line: "Forget it, Jake. It's Chinatown..." ■

The poster for *Chinatown* suggests an old-fashioned film noir, with a chain-smoking detective and a femme fatale. But Polanski effectively subverts the genre and plays with audience expectations.



Roman Polanski
Director

Born in Paris in 1933 to Polish parents, Roman Polanski grew up in Poland. During World War II, his parents were sent to a concentration camp where his mother died, but Roman survived by hiding in the countryside. After the war, he went to film school. His first feature movie, *Knife in the Water* (1962), was acclaimed internationally, and he moved to the UK to make movies such as the chilling *Repulsion*. In 1968, he met actress Sharon Tate and moved to the US, where he made the horror movie *Rosemary's Baby*. The following year, Tate was murdered by the serial killers known as the Manson Family. Polanski left the US but was invited back to direct *Chinatown*. A few years later, he was convicted of unlawful sex with a minor and fled to France, where he still directs.

Key movies

1965 *Repulsion*
1968 *Rosemary's Baby*
1974 *Chinatown*
1979 *Tess*
1988 *Frantic*
2002 *The Pianist*